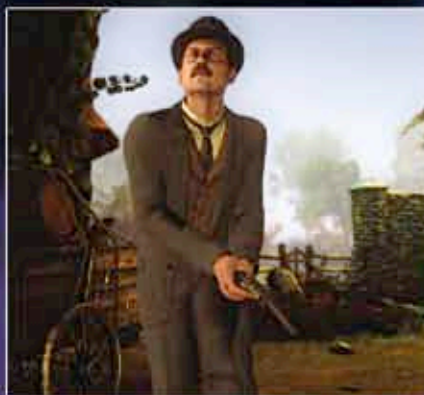


We found the change quite engaging and think fans of the series will see it as a welcome and rewarding change of pace.

One of our personal favorites that isn't getting the attention it deserves is *The Testament of Sherlock Holmes*. Published by Focus Home Entertainment and available for PC, Xbox 360, and PlayStation 3, *Testament* is an open-world point and click type adventure game wherein you play Sherlock as he tries to unravel a mystery that places him as the lead suspect. You decide which leads to follow and which direction to take, with freedom to explore clues and investigate areas in the order you feel might work best. A new graphics engine was developed for the game, and it shows. The environments look lovely and unlike previous Holmes games, the gore is on full display. It is certainly being developed with adults in mind (though it isn't vulgar or offensive in any way) and this is a good thing, as it fits perfectly for those of us who grew up playing PC adventure games. If you are one of those people then take a close look when the game releases in September.

There were a host of other great looking exclusives for the PC. *Arma 3* aims to take first person shooters in a more serious direction, with strategy and directed combat. *End of Nations* looks to turn the real-time strategy genre on its head by combining the familiar game play with a persistent, massively multiplayer world. *PlanetSide 2* is a free-to-play massively multiplayer shooter from Sony Online Entertainment. The scope of combat was amazing and the entire game looked impressive. *Hawken* is another free-to-play title, set in a futuristic world and featuring mech combat. It's clear from these two games that free-to-play has turned a serious corner and is looking to bring in even the most hardcore gamers.

The WiiU, again, came away a bit disappointing. While many were expecting a redesigned game pad we instead received a "pro" controller that lacked a screen and looked suspiciously similar to the Xbox 360 game pad. There were frustratingly few games on display, with almost one-third of their booth dedicated to Nintendoland, their collection



of mini games expected to launch with the system. *New Super Mario Bros* for WiiU was on display, and looked nice but uninspired. If you enjoyed the game on Wii then it will most certainly be more of the same kind of fun, but it lacked the punch that one normally wants to see in a high profile launch title for a new gaming console. *Pikmin 3* was also being shown, but only using the original Wii wand and playing very much the same as *Pikmin 2*. Much of what was on display for the WiiU from other publishers amounted to little more than ports with little thought gone in to how to use the tablet controller in unique ways. With only 6 games promised for the "launch window" which is a long 3-4 months wait, I'd suggest a wait and see attitude with this console. No price or specific launch date was announced.

Sony's star of the show was undoubtedly *The Last of Us*. Developed by Naughty Dog, who also developed *Uncharted*, this was one of the few true surprises of the show for most people. On one hand the game appears to be a fairly typical adventure game, featuring action, gunplay, stealth, and platforming. But what truly set it apart was the depth with which the game handled all of its characters. While it is expected that protagonists in games will have life to them, this game seems to be handling all of the enemies with an equally high level of detail. You won't be taking on generic hordes. Instead you will be faced with enemies that have personality, motives, and humanity in a way that isn't familiar in gaming. That should

make each decision (and each kill) more difficult. The graphic engine for the game is equally impressive, and most of the audience was amazed at what was being done on such old hardware. Another star of the show for PlayStation, though it was tucked away hidden upstairs, is the upcoming "Cross Platform" update for *LittleBigPlanet*. This free downloadable update will allow you to interact with the game using a Sony Vita. Players will be able to build tools so that the Vita can be used as a touch screen controller, and they showed this with fun functions like using it as a radar to find items, or to drag objects around the main screen. What we thought was even more exciting was the cooperative, asymmetrical multiplayer aspect of the update. One player controls something on the Vita while another does something completely different on the TV, while you have to talk to help each other cooperate. It was quite fun.

*Halo 4* was of course on display and looked fantastic. Despite showings from *Gears of War* and *Forza*, it was definitely *Halo* that stole the show for Microsoft. With a new developer on board for this sequel many were unsure of what to expect, but seeing it at the show relieved any uncertainty. It is clear that the development team at 343 has great love for the series and any changes they make will stay true to what fans expect. The sound design was particularly impressive, with atmospheric and gun effects sounding considerably better than any other game in the series. *Gears of War: Judgment* looked like more of the same for the series, though a new multiplayer mode called *Overrun* did look like fun. Other than that, expect a host of Xbox Live Arcade and Kinect titles from Microsoft this year.

By the end of the show it was clear that while the three consoles manufacturers were busy throwing punches, the PC came away as the clear victor. While each console had a handful of exclusive games, the vast majority of what was on display this year is either PC exclusive or will look best on a PC. Consoles will have to wait until next year for their day in the spotlight. ✱